

State of Discomfort

Of the six Karnataka constituencies Rahul visited, the Congress won two

The party's star campaigner touched base on the second leg of the three-phase campaign in Karnataka. During the two days of his campaign, Rahul visited six constituencies, of which the party won two. Claims Captain Praveen Dawar, AICC secretary in charge of Karnataka, "We got the maximum Muslim and tribal seats because of him." Indeed, Rahul went to great lengths to educate them about the various legislations passed by the UPA in

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IT'S SHOWTIME: Rahul focussed on the tribal belt

their favour, like the Tribal Bill and the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme. Despite his earnest efforts, though, he could not win Chikmagalur, the constituency that voted for Indira Gandhi in a post-Emergency by-election.

Unlike BJP, which had fielded a strong regional leader, the Congress was banking on the Gandhi charisma. But as the party—and perhaps Rahul, too—has realised, airdropping from a chopper stirs more dust than it makes inroads. With the Congress losing a state that once stood by it through thick and thin, there is clearly a postscript here for the young scion to figure out.



THE HIGH COMMAND: Rahul with Sonia Gandhi and Manmohan Singh

make false promises, whether to drought-ridden farmers in Karnataka, who asked for an extension of the loan waiver, or to impoverished potters in Chhattisgarh, who asked him for two more handpumps. "It is not possible to give relief to everyone. A government policy is a balancing act. The Government can't do something which might make the whole system collapse," he told the farmers, while the potters were lectured about the water table. Said a party colleague, "His father would have opted for a flamboyant gesture, turned to Mani Shankar Aiyar and said, 'Mani, see that they get the pumps'." Rahul's bluntness can be quite disconcerting for the average Congressman, for whom flattery has been the only communication with the High Command. At an Uttar Pradesh committee meet soon after the state elections, when Congressmen told him that the Samajwadi Party was losing its base, he simply asked, "Then how did it win so many seats and we so few?" When he wants to, the mercurial Gandhi can turn on his father's charm. In Raipur, he walked into a packed press conference in the sweltering summer and laughed, "Why are you so quiet? Has the heat got to you?" When the media began squabbling for the microphone, he sat back with a smile and said, "This is your fight, not my problem."

While in the capital, his social engagements vary from high-profile cricket matches to five-star indul-

gences, from Pilot's 30th birthday bash to a quiet evening at Orissa industrial-turned-MP Jai Panda's, where he had dinner with Finance Minister P. Chidambaram and Minister for Science Kapil Sibal, among others. And of course, there are the pedicures at a south Delhi salon, which shuts shop whenever the Gandhi scion drops in. Linger customers are greeted with a warm "Hi there". Like his brother-in-law Robert Vadra, he is fond of workouts and is quite happy discussing gym techniques with strangers. In Bundelkhand, he recently surprised a local wrestler by asking him to throw a punch and discussed the pros and cons of bantamweight and lightweight boxing.

It was only during the 2007 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections, three years after he became an MP, that Rahul ventured out of his playpen in Amethi, packed some Diet Coke in his light-blue picnic basket and set out to explore the rest of India. A year later, the reluctant leader is slowly coming to terms with his destiny. Rahul's love for off-beat Japanese cinema may have prepared him for the bizarre and the unexpected, but he has made it clear that he will only take over the party leadership when he is ready. His father may have become prime minister at 40, but even as the Congress desperately needs a strong, charismatic leader with mass appeal, Rahul thinks he is not that leader. Not yet.

with Subhash Mishra and Stephen David